



Write to the Editor

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build such kind of software at such a low price, they told me that if the local hardware vendor could give it to them for free, why did I charge so high? I did not know how to react. Public awareness of piracy, I have realised, is almost zero in many places in India.

The truth is that our government and big MNCs have not given any option to our citizens, but to use pirated software. After all, how many people are able to afford the right software at the exorbitant prices?

Maybe the government in collaboration with software giants like Microsoft, Oracle, Adobe, etc, could build a software centre in every Indian city that helps people buy software at reasonable rates so that piracy is minimised.

Pratik Dutta
Burdwan

The Editor replies:

Dear Pratik,

It is sad, but true, that a majority of software used in India is pirated. This is the same case in China, south-east Asia, and Africa, where developing economies find it difficult to come to terms with high cost of software.

Software cost is a piquant issue—developing companies say their price software based on the amount invested, manhours spent, the intellectual capital invested in developing the software, the royalties, etc. On the other hand, customers say the same software could be priced much lower to make it accessible to several more people.

It is a debate that will rage for quite some time to come. Having said that, let me congratulate you on the stand you took against piracy, even if it meant you lost a couple of customers.

The Blame Game

Your November editorial 'How Broad Is Your Broadband?' asked the ISPs the right questions. However, I wish to share and highlight some of my broadband experiences.

It is not that broadband

speeds of more than 256 Kbps are not available. In Hyderabad, where I stay, I have two connections at home, both being data transfer packages. Both these services have given me no cause for complaint, and typical speeds on the Sify connection is around 240-250 Kbps, whereas my other service provider Beam gives me speeds of up to 400 Kbps.

These are speeds I checked with McAfee Speedometer, CNET Bandwidth Meter, and a couple of other sites.

The problem with broadband is not that ISPs do not have bandwidth, but that customers themselves do not want broadband at the rates offered by them. For instance, when I called up my local broadband ISP, the person told me that only one in 20 customers ask for high speed connections. Most customers want a flat-fee (lowest price) package, and are willing to settle for 32 to 48 Kbps for unlimited usage!

Quality of connections also vary from point to point even within the same city. Besides, I do not think speeds beyond 512 Kbps would add any value to most home users, except if they are watching movies on pay-per-view Web sites that stream data at a rate of 512 Kbps.

Indians, being price-conscious, are wary of high-speed connections because of high bandwidth costs. Compare this with Singapore where ISPs routinely offer 3 Mbps connections for home users. In Malaysia, it is common for cyber cafes to host at least 40 simultaneous persons playing online games.

Therefore, I do not think that ISPs alone are to blame for the broadband mess in India.

Saketh Ram
Via e-mail

The Editor replies:

Dear Saketh,

That was a very perceptive analysis. While I agree that ISPs alone are not responsible for the broadband mess in India, I also feel they have a great role to play in evangelising this service. In a price-sensitive market like India, both the ISPs and the government should realise that freeing up bandwidth will only lead to greater usage of broadband, and over a period, reduce costs.

A good example would be the use cellular services in India. When they were first launched, India had the most expensive telecommunications costs. Now India has one of the cheapest cellular services in the world.

SMS Spk—A Boon Or A Curse

I am an e-mail and SMS addict, and an early adopter of technology innovations. Therefore, I can identify well with the article, "The Bending of the Rules" (Digit, November 2004).

Examples of 'SMS-speak' should not be classified as works of art, right now. Purely because we do not use SMS-speak while conversing with each other (and I suspect it would be rather difficult to do that!). More importantly, body language itself is an integral part of one-to-one human communication. As Dr Jill Walker puts it, "SMS-speak should stay the way it is—another mode of communication." She also says that 'SMS-speak' is "creative, sophisticated and can have poetic beauty when used well."

My perspective is that the creativity, sophistication and poetic beauty be attributed to the thought rather than the mode of expression.

Let me elucidate. I have a friend who composes great limericks, and is an SMS-junkie to boot. These days he sends me his creative gems via 'SMS-speak'. The beauty of the verse is not lost in 'translation' to SMS-speak, if you quickly understand what the verse is like in 'proper' English. But to a layman, the entire message could be mindless gibberish.

The moot point here, I suppose, is communication, and on that point 'SMS-speak' wins hands down. But if it were to be taken as an art, we need to answer a few pertinent questions:

Chinese writer Qian Fuchang's novel way of publishing a novel on SMS raises the question whether this work should be preserved in 'SMS-speak', and be considered a novelty, or 'deciphered' into 'proper' English and saved for posterity?

Academics should also be kept free of 'SMS-speak', except while communicating informally. If not, we need to ask whether we want our future generations to converse succinctly, or in code.

Thirdly, 'proper' English should be encouraged in face-to-face communications, as a person who speaks the language properly would have less chance of learning 'wrong' English from SMS-speak.

Abhik Sen
Kolkata

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OF THE
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